

Okay, so we've got a couple of games under the belt. We're going to do a new one that is specifically related to game management. There are other materials previously recorded related to game management, especially the live sessions that Angus did with his team in San Diego that covered some of this. This is going to be a very simple game design with a small group of players as usual, and we'll try to make it modular so that it can be scaled up to accommodate any number of players. So as usual, same scenario, I'm a player, I'm not really sure how to approach the game design thing. I know I've got a few friends coming out, there are going to be roughly eight of us, we've got some field space in the park, just some grass, and I'm giving my friend Angus a call to ask him how can we go about this. So the questions I'm asking of Angus are, hey Angus, we've got eight guys, we've got roughly an hour to work with, maybe a little bit over an hour. We want to get a good run in, and we want to work on our space management. We're giving him the assumption that the park is infinitely big, so he can use as much space as he wants to. I'm going to be asking him specifically how wide and how long the field should be for every one of these games. If the field lengths and widths are changing, either in the game itself or between rounds, I'll be asking him why those changes happen and what the metrics are, like am I working with roughly three meters per player or ten meters per player in width, for example. Okay, let's get going. So Angus, you heard the sort of intro there, we've got eight players coming out, we've got plenty of field space, everything's been cleared and safe, we don't have to worry about that stuff. It's just a couple of us, we want to get a run in, and we specifically want to work on our space management. How do we go about it? We've got eight guys. Do you want to do attacking space or defensive space? Is it possible to do both at the same time, or is it better to just focus on one? Both will happen, symbiotically, but you kind of need to have a decision on which side of the ball, which aspect you want to focus on, because otherwise it gets confusing as you evolve. Okay, let's focus on attack. So you've got eight people, so I would start with four a side, let's keep it even, four a side, 30 metres of width. If they're not very good, maybe 40 metres of width. And then around, let's say 50 metres of depth, and the reason for depth, so let's call width is horizontal or lateral space, and depth is vertical space. So the reason I say 50 metres is because many players will accelerate, and some will still be accelerating at more than 20 metres before they plateau, and then maintain a speed. Players will accelerate and plateau between 5, 10 and 15 metres, so you need to give them room to accelerate, then plateau and adjust, and then keep the attacking continuity going. So we'll say four a side, 50 metres of vertical space, 30 metres of lateral space, and then just basic touch rugby. So every time you get tagged with the ball, I like to work in the rule of threes. So let's say every time you get three goes to create your space, so you get three touches after which, if you haven't broken the D-line, you have to turn the ball over to the other side. So if you haven't broken the D-line, in other words, you've kind of made a clean break, or do you mean like after three touches, if you haven't scored, it's the other team's ball? So I think for this game, let's do it this way. You do three touches, and if the fourth touch happens, it's an immediate turnover. So at the third touch, you're trying to keep the ball alive. Even if you're going backwards, you just know that you're trying to keep the ball alive. So you can move laterally, obviously, within that 30-metre expansion, but vertically, you can go back to come forward as well, which is important, because if you just try and press forward, you end up compressing so much space that you're going to end up with a majority fail. Go. So off each touch, let's say it's a single-hand touch, which is kind of easy to achieve for the defender. So we are playing off each touch, the ball can be kept in play. So you kind of keep it moving, or if you choose, you can go to ground with the ball and recycle it and have it go out that way. So if you've got a single-hand touch that comes with an offload, the touch counts, but the attack and continuity keeps going, so there's no offside, just an open field play. If you've got a single-hand touch and the ball carrier decides to go to ground, which simulates a contact environment, then the defensive team has to go back and get onside, and the attacking team can go as fast or as slow as it likes. So attacking team, under those rules, the attacking player gets touched, they would go to ground, for example, and then the player who made the touch would be retreating back a couple of metres along with the rest of their team. Yeah, the whole team has to go back, let's say, two or three metres, but far enough away that allows the attacking team to reset and go again. And it's important for the quality of the game that they do that. Every team sport and every game of any kind has rules, and discipline is important for the rules to have value. What would you do if, let's say, the defending team consistently doesn't drop back, just that touch didn't count towards the total count? So let's say the attacking team has the ball, they just got touched for the third time, their player goes to ground, but the defensive team isn't appropriately retreating, like they drop back half a metre or

something before they start pressing again on the defence. Either as someone sort of refereeing, overseeing this game, or the players themselves managing it, what is the agreed-upon rule that gets applied if the defensive team doesn't obey the rule of dropping back? Do we just reset the touch count? I think so, keep it simple. In a game, there's rewards, scoring is a reward, but then there has to be penalties for infractions, like all things, rugby's like life. So you have to have, if, I would, I like to do things in a way where you penalise severity. So having played traditional touch rugby where it's so cut and dried, for me personally as an athlete, learner type, it's not fun, because there's no flexibility. So what I would do in this game is, first offence is that touch doesn't count, and then same with the second offence, and maybe the third offence, you say that's a total reset. So you can't, you have to punish infractions, but it has to have a material impact. So if the infraction has no material impact on the other side, or the action of the game, then philosophically, why are you penalising it? Whereas if the infraction has a material impact, then the penalty has to have a material outcome. Yeah, okay, alright. I think those are simple things to work from, and the players can decide amongst themselves how they want to... Yeah, definitely, it comes down to how the players want to manage it, and the facilitator or the coach, or whoever's acting referee, keep it simple enough to implement. The more complicated it gets, the more it's going to fail. So we've got two teams of four, we've got the field dimensions, game one, simple rules, and fourth touch, we do a turnover, unless the team scores before then, in which case it's a turnover, and they play for 15 minutes, they come off the field, they have a little break, drink some water, they've got roughly three minutes to work with. What should the app be relaying to them for the progression to the next game, or at least what are the options that they can choose from? What are we giving them to choose from? So first thing is the counter, so off the first touch for example, sorry, off the fourth touch for example, okay, if the turnover is at the try, right, where are you starting from? Are you starting from the try line, or are you starting from up the field? Sure. Are you giving possession and territory, or just possession, or, yeah, that's really important to consider. Equally if you want to make it harder, so this is a kind of standard game, it's fairly fluid, so attacking is one of the hardest principles to develop, the attacking framework is so hard that when you look at, historically, if you look at the last 20 plus years of rugby, it became very defensive and reductive in a professional environment because people are frightened of losing, so never forget that attacking is hard. So in this game, what I would do as another option for a progression is, you're playing four on four, let's change it to five on three. So we've got progression number one, where the turnover occurs, is it just possession or are you awarding possession and territory? And progression option number two is, give the attacking team more players to work with, because when you incorporate horizontal and lateral movement, it's not a linear outcome, and attacking is fundamentally harder to achieve than defense. So having a five on three arrangement, you're still actually, whilst the numbers are skewed in favor of the attack, the probability outcome of a defensive win is still just as high. So how do we, if I think about this, how do I cycle through that team? So we've had our first game, 15 minutes, we've come off, we've had some water, and we've been given the option to play a game as the second game that is five on three. How do I cycle through and make sure that in the 15 minutes we're playing, that everyone sort of gets a go at attack and defense? Yeah, that's pretty easy actually. So for the attacking side, if the attacking side are winning, for example, the player who scores goes into the defensive side, and he or she picks the person who goes into the attacking side. Okay. Right, so it's really important that you leave that up to the players to self-assess rather than the coach, because it's kind of better, I think, to have player bias than coach or facilitator bias. The other way to do it is if the defensive side is winning, so the defensive side is trapping the ball, forcing turnovers, there's a couple of ways to do this. So one way to do it is they can earn a player back. So every time they get a turnover, they can pull a player out from the other side. So they've gone five on three, now to four on four. If they maintain dominance, now they can say, right, they score four on four, or they retain the ball. Let's say they retain the ball in play for two minutes, and then they get to pick the fifth player, and now they're on five on three. And then you go back to if they score, the player who scores goes back to the other side and reset it that way. Defensively also, three on five, you could even do a clean sweep. So let's, for argument's sake, the three win the ball through an intercept or a turnover and score a try. They're now the attacking team, so they pick two players from the other side, and they become the five on three. All right, so very simple, I've got five players, one, two, three, four, five on one side, and then I've got the other three players, six, seven, eight on the other team. Let's say player number one from the team of five who's attacking scores, that player then has to go over to the defensive side. And switch out. So he switches, he picks

player six, seven, or eight, he nominates one of those players to go over to the attacking side. Yeah, so you're still saying we're the five on three, but we're cycling through players. Right, and then when you restart, it's the attacking team gets the ball. And other than that, you just like, you play same rules as the first game, like at the fourth touch, ball turns over, so if the team with the three players in it makes four touches, they get the ball, now they're attacking, but just with three players. Totally, because it's really important that when you change the condition, you can't change too much. So in that game, if the purpose of five on three is about generating confidence with ball movement and attacking space, then you really don't want to degrade the five on three. But you want to give players an opportunity to play both sides, because they have to learn space management from both sides of the ball. And so in this case, it's skewed attack, so you really kind of want the attack to succeed, so they're learning about how to be better in attack. And so yeah, I would keep it very simple. Okay, so 15 minutes, so second game's done, get a little break, water, got two, three minutes to relay the next set of rules to the guys. What's the last one? Third round, attacking team can kick. Okay. Easy peasy, so it's all been catch pass, catch pass, so with the attacking team, even at five on three, even with the odds in their favour, and this is the whole thing, we have to remember attacking is hard, right, it's skillful, it's better if it's non-reductive, so space management, skills management, these are really important things to achieve, and take the longest time to evolve. So even with a five on three, they might run out of options. So give them a chance, we're not, in a game like this, we're trying to stay away from contact because we're still trying to play evasion game, so allow them to kick and chase. And what that does, it completely blows everything up, blows up the whole pattern, the whole structure, the defence will not totally dissolve, but it has to, it has to like scramble and realign and the offence doesn't mean they're going to get the ball back, but they also have to like put, you know, it allows them to recalibrate or reframe their challenge from a different geographical position. Great, okay, simple stuff, if they kick the ball and it goes out, turn over? Yep. Okay. So, but the thing is you have to be cautious, so if we're doing five on three, if they kick the ball and it goes, so this is the thing that you want to reward smart attacking. So I would say in this game, particularly in the third progression, so we're trying to get really challenging and really smart. So in the third game, I would say, for example, if you kick the ball, you want to keep it in play, so that's much more space management, live space management, so if it goes out, you get punished for sending it out, therefore the other team get the ball and the pick of two players, they immediately go to, they're the five on three now. Well, okay, got it. Another option could be that wherever you kicked it from is where the other team gets the ball or something like that? Yeah, or you could do in that situation again, because we're trying to, we're trying to make the kick an extension of the attack, not a stoppage. So another thing you could do, if they've kicked it, it's gone out of play, so you could also say, right, you give the other team a choice. They can stay down there and become a five on three, but from that point, or they can go back to where the kick was made and become a four on four and bring one person over and then earn the right again to become a five on five, but now we're in the third progression and we want everyone to be smart, if they choose the four on four option, the possession of the ball can go either way, so if the other team again snatches it, gets their three touches or the fourth touch in, they get the right to pull a player back and become five on three again and have all those rights and overlaps and advantages. And that's a really good strategy and tactic game, just that one thing alone with just eight people, you could play that for an hour and you could stop, even if, so you just spoke here about first round, second round, third round, so first progression, sorry, standard game, so your baseline game, first progression, second progression, that's what all that was. If you're in a situation where you have a coach or a facilitator and you want to reassess, you could also have those moments, right, let's stop, have a water break, what's working, what's not working, how are we going to improve, right, so you can actually fold that learning opportunity into the game. Always go back to the game because games like that, actually games like we've just described, players freaking love that stuff, they love it and they will play that forever, you'd probably get 50 to 100% more engagement and time out of players doing something like that than you ever would in any standard structured training environment. Yeah, I can agree, okay, so session's wrapping up, everyone's nice and tired, we've got three games behind us, like roughly 45 minutes of active game time and obviously, you know, as the setting that we're talking in, we didn't observe these actual games, so we don't have necessarily things to reference, but what are the types of questions that you'd be sort of asking of the group in reflection of this session typically? So, just coming back a bit on that, just going back to the Pareto principle, right, I would say if you've got a 60-minute window

of activity, play 48 minutes, 48 to 50 minutes, so as the facilitator or the coach, you have to be really disciplined, so you have to be prepared and allow yourself only 10-odd minutes of talk and discussion, and so, and then at the close... Sorry, and that 10 minutes includes set up time between games, you really don't have much time at the end of the session, is what you're saying, you have maybe like... Yeah, and I know I've said it before, time to action, but if you're setting up a game, if I'm giving you 10 minutes of game time, right, I don't need to say shit, sorry, I don't need to say anything, and if I can't, if you're not going between 60 and 90 seconds, it's already too complex, right? So, if we have three games, three games with three intros, with a new rule, just basically new rule, very little discussion, that's three minutes, so one minimum of three minutes, maximum of four and a half, five minutes on the intro, intro, intro, so when you get to the end of it, yeah, you've got five to seven minutes, you're at the end anyway, so it's going to slow, even if you spill over, because you know there's no more activity, right, so it's going to take a couple of minutes, okay, calm down, take a deep breath, get some water, let's go back to base camp, walk over to base camp, you're over at base camp, and then it's a case of, okay, this is what we did, right? Game one was this, game two was this, game three was this, our focus was attacking, right, and what we did is we skewed the game to benefit attacking, but it doesn't mean attacking always wins, what did we learn, what did we learn about attacking, what did we learn about defense, and then make sure everyone answers, so you're always going to get one person who's got three or four answers, which is fine, and don't choke them, but you've got to say, okay, you've given me two answers, I want to hear from the others, what did you learn, because you need to know that all your learner groups are learning something, even if it's one thing, and in real terms, if one person has learned one thing, learned and retained one thing over 50 minutes, that's a pretty good return on investment, that's a realistic return on investment. Okay, great.